Chapter 19 – Mohandas Gandhi

"If this Empire seems an evil thing to me, it is not because I hate the British, I hate only the Empire."

(Gandhi)

India needed a homegrown hero, and it found one by the name of Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi—better known as "Mahatma" Gandhi, or "high-souled" in Sanskrit. Born to a family within the sub-caste of Baniya on October 2nd, 1869, Gandhi spent his early childhood in the coastal princely state of Porbandar. True to his high caste, his father, Karamchand, had an administrative position as the chief minister of Porbander State. Karamchand married four times; his first two wives died, and he had a polygamous marriage with the second two. His fourth wife, Putlibai, had four children, the last of whom would help lead India out of the colonial age and into a new era of republicanism.

Gandhi's father was an average Hindu, but his mother worshiped a subsect of Hinduism, known as Pranami Vaishnavism. Putlibai's religion focused on Lord Vishnu, who is considered by members of her sect to be the supreme lord of all other deities, including Lord Krishna, who is considered another embodiment of Vishnu. Gandhi's mother was a very devout woman, who regularly performed fasts she believed purified her body and mind. Her influence would have a great effect on Mohandas when he became a politically minded adult.

The family moved to Rajkot in 1874, and there, Mohandas and his siblings attended school. As was custom, boys were married to a girl his parents chose for him. At the time of the wedding, Mohandas was 13 years old, and his bride, Kasturbai Makhanji Kapadia, was fourteen. Still in their teens, the young couple welcomed their first baby in 1885, but it died in infancy, sadly within months of Mohandas' own father. The loss weighed heavily on Gandhi, who was still attending high school. A few years later, he graduated and immediately looked to enroll for post-secondary studies in the cheapest college of his state. Soon after being accepted, however, he dropped out and decided to pursue legal studies in Great Britain.

Mohandas' brother, already a British-trained lawyer, supported this decision and offered to help with expenses. Putlibai, however, was worried that her son would be tempted to cast aside his Hindu beliefs if he spent so much